

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

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TIFFANY TEAGUE,

Plaintiffs,

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, NYPD DETECTIVE
SONEY VARGHESE, Shield No. 3642, NYPD
DETECTIVE ROBERT DECK, Shield No. 2493, and
NYPD POLICE OFFICERS JOHN AND JANE DOES
NUMBERS ONE THROUGH SIX,

Defendants.
----- x

SUMMONS

Index No.:

The Basis of Venue is:
Location of Incident

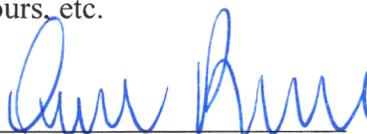
Plaintiff designates Kings
County as the place of trial

To the above-named defendants:

You are hereby summoned to answer the Verified Complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your Verified Answer to the Verified Complaint, or, if the Verified Complaint is not served with this Summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the Plaintiff's attorneys within twenty days after the service of this Summons, exclusive of the day of service, where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or, within 30 days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

DATED: New York, New York
March 6, 2023

Yours, etc.



Omar T. Russo
Shulman-Hill, PLLC
Attorneys for Plaintiff
1 State Street Plaza, 15th Floor
New York, New York 10004
(212) 203-1090

TO: THE CITY OF NEW YORK, Corporation Counsel, 100 Church Street, New York, New York 10007

NYPD DETECTIVE SONEY VARGHESE, Shield No. 3642, 73rd Precinct; 1470 East New York Avenue; Brooklyn, New York 11212

NYPD DETECTIVE ROBERT DECK, Shield No. 2493, 81st Precinct; 30 Ralph Avenue, Brooklyn, New York 11221

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS----- X
TIFFANY TEAGUE,

Plaintiffs,

INDEX NO.:

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, NYPD DETECTIVE
SONEY VARGHESE, Shield No. 3642, NYPD
DETECTIVE ROBERT DECK, Shield No. 2493, and
NYPD POLICE OFFICERS JOHN AND JANE DOES
NUMBERS ONE THROUGH SIX,

JURY TRIAL DEMANDED

Defendants.
----- X

Plaintiff, TIFFANY TEAGUE, by her attorneys, Shulman-Hill, PLLC, as and for her Verified Complaint herein, alleges upon information and belief as follows:

PRELIMINARY STATEMENT

1. This is a civil rights action to recover money damages arising out of defendants' violations of Plaintiff's rights as secured by the Civil Rights Act, 42 U.S.C. Sections 1983 and 1988, and of rights secured by the First, Fourth, Fifth, and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, and the common law and the laws of the State of New York. On December 12, 2022, at approximately 2:00 p.m., Plaintiff, while lawfully in the vicinity of 30 Ralph Avenue, County of Kings, New York, was subject to an unlawful detention, arrest, excessive use of force, and violations of her First Amendment Rights by the defendant officers. In addition, Plaintiff was subjected to approximately twenty-four (24) hours in unlawful custody by defendant officers at the NYPD 81st Precinct and Kings County Central Bookings before she was arraigned in criminal court, charged with crimes she did not commit, and released on her own recognizance. The charges falsely levied against Plaintiff by the defendant officers were dismissed and sealed on or about May 15, 2023. Plaintiff was deprived of her rights under 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 802 and her constitutional, common law, and statutory rights when the individual defendants unlawfully stopped, detained, subjected to excessive force, maliciously prosecuted, and passed along false accusations to prosecuting attorneys against the Plaintiff, in violation of the First, Fourth, Fifth, and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, the common law and the laws of the State of New York.

PARTIES

2. Plaintiff, Tiffany Teague, is a resident of the State of New York.
3. NYPD Detective Soney Varghese, Shield No. 3642, is and was at all times relevant herein an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.
4. NYPD Detective Soney Varghese, Shield No. 3642, is being sued in his individual and official capacities.
5. At all times relevant herein, NYPD Detective Soney Varghese, Shield No. 3642, was assigned to the 73rd Precinct.
6. NYPD Detective Robert Deck, Shield No. 2493, is and was at all times relevant herein an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.
7. NYPD Detective Robert Deck, Shield No. 2493, is being sued in his individual and official capacities.
8. At all times relevant herein, NYPD Detective Robert Deck, Shield No. 2493, was assigned to the 81st Precinct.
9. New York City Police Officers John and Jane Does #1-6 are and were at all times relevant herein officers, employees, and agents of the New York City Police Department.
10. New York City Police Officers John and Jane Does #1-6 are being sued in their individual and official capacities.
11. At all times relevant herein, the individual defendants were acting under color of state law in the course and scope of their duties and functions as agents, servants, employees and officers of the New York City Police Department, and otherwise performed and engaged in conduct incidental to the performance of their lawful functions in the course of their duties. They were acting for and on behalf of the New York City Police Department at all times relevant herein, with the power and authority vested in them as officers, agents and employees of the New York City Police Department and incidental to the lawful pursuit of their duties as officers, employees and agents of the New York City Police Department.
12. Defendant City of New York is a municipal entity created and authorized under the laws of the State of New York. It is authorized by law to maintain a police department, which acts as its agent in the area of law enforcement and for which it is ultimately responsible. The defendant City of New York assumes the risks incidental to the maintenance of a police force and the employment of police officers as said risks attach to the public consumers of the services provided by the New York City Police Department.

13. Plaintiff in furtherance of her causes of action brought pursuant to New York State law filed a timely Notice of Claim against the City of New York in compliance with the Municipal Law Section 50 and in accordance with New York State law.

14. In accordance with New York State law and General Municipal Law Section 50, Plaintiff testified at a hearing held pursuant to General Municipal Law Section 50-H on February 16, 2024.

15. More than thirty (30) days have elapsed since service of said Notice of Claim was filed and the City of New York has failed to pay or adjust the claims.

16. This action falls within one or more of the exceptions as set forth in CPLR Section 1602, involving intentional actions, as well as the defendant, and/or defendants, having acted in reckless disregard for the safety of others, as well as having performed intentional acts.

17. Plaintiff has sustained damages in an amount in excess of the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts of the State of New York.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

18. On December 12, 2022, at approximately 2:00 p.m., Plaintiff was lawfully present in the vicinity of 30 Ralph Avenue, New York, when the defendant officers unlawfully arrested her without probable cause or legal justification.

19. Plaintiff visited the 81st Precinct to meet and follow up with detectives after multiple conversations and reports involving her son's harassment and assault by students at his school.

20. On multiple occasions prior to the referenced date, Plaintiff had communicated with detectives and other officers at or associated with the 81st Precinct seeking assistance for her son.

21. Plaintiff's minor child is developmentally disabled and had been subjected to bullying by a group of students from his school in the months prior to the incident, including physically attacking him in and out of school.

22. After failed attempts to resolve the matter with the school directly, Plaintiff sought the assistance of the 81st Precinct.

23. Plaintiff sent text messages, photos, and videos to the defendant officers demonstrating the extent and severity of her son's bullying.

24. In November 2022, Plaintiff's son was badly attacked in the vicinity of his school, Eagle Academy for Young Men, in Brooklyn.

25. Plaintiff received a call from her eldest son, who explained that the younger, disabled son was being attacked.

26. Plaintiff and her husband immediately responded to the scene and attempted to break up the boys.

27. Plaintiff attempted to guard her young son from being hit, and spread her arms out to separate the boys.

28. Over a dozen school children surrounded the fight, filming the incident on their smartphones.

29. Also present were adult civilians, observing the fight, but offering to assistance to Plaintiff's child.

30. At no time relevant herein did Plaintiff commit a crime or violate the law in any way, nor did the police officers have an objective basis to accuse Plaintiff of committing a crime or violating the law in any way.

31. In fact, quite the contrary, the defendant officers possessed photos and videos demonstrating that Plaintiff had committed no wrongdoing whatsoever.

32. Plaintiff voluntarily reported to the 81st Precinct on the date of her arrest to provide additional information regarding her son's various attacks. Instead, she was unlawfully and baselessly arrested.

33. At no point did the defendant officers recover any drugs, weapons, graffiti instruments, or other illegal contraband from Plaintiff or from a location that was in Plaintiff's possession, custody, or control.

34. Plaintiff did not resist arrest at any point.

35. Nevertheless, Plaintiff was unlawfully arrested and tightly handcuffed by the defendant officers without probable cause or legal justification.

36. Plaintiff's misfortune had, however, only just begun as the defendant officers would thereafter engage in a grotesque campaign of constitution violations.

37. Plaintiff was directed to remove her head covering to be photographed.

38. Plaintiff explained multiple times that she is a practicing Muslim, and that it is forbidden for men outside her family to touch or see her hair.

39. She pleaded with the officers to simply pat down around her head scarf to ensure she did not have any contraband within the head covering.

40. Plaintiff attempted to protest for several minutes but was continually pressured and intimidated by Detective Varghese to remove the hijab to avoid “making things worse” for herself.

41. In fact, the detective insisted that if Plaintiff were compliant, she would be quickly released with a desk appearance ticket, but that if she did not, she would be put through the system.

42. Desperate to return to her children, Plaintiff considered the detective’s direction.

43. Plaintiff looked to a female police officer, who advised Plaintiff that she understood, but could not do anything, that she was outranked by the detective.

44. The detective then placed his hand inside of Plaintiff’s hijab, touching and exposing her hair.

45. Plaintiff, aggrieved and ashamed, removed her hijab for the photograph based on the promise of a quick release.

46. Thereafter, Plaintiff was fingerprinted, photographed, and placed in a holding cell.

47. After approximately 10 hours at the 81st Precinct, Plaintiff was transported to Kings County Central Bookings.

48. While Plaintiff was in custody, the defendant police officers provided the Kings County District Attorney’s Office with the obviously false, misleading, and/or incomplete information that Plaintiff had committed crimes; specifically, menacing; acting in a manner injurious to a child; criminal possession of a weapon; and harassment.

49. On December 13, 2022, Plaintiff was arraigned in Kings County Criminal Court, charged with the crimes she did not commit, and was released on her own recognizance despite the officers’ severe and false allegations.

50. On or about May 15, 2023, all charges against Plaintiff were dismissed and the records thereof sealed in their entirety.

51. Plaintiff continues to suffer from the shame, embarrassment, humiliation, and mental anguish associated with the grave violation of her religion she was forced to perpetuate based on the defendant officers’ actions.

52. Some of the police officer defendants observed the violation of Plaintiff’s rights under the Constitution of the United States and New York State Law and did nothing to prevent their fellow officers from unjustifiably arresting, confining, and using excessive force against Plaintiff.

53. The unlawful arrest, confinement, use of excessive force, and violation of First Amendment rights by the individually named defendants caused Plaintiff to sustain physical, psychological, and emotional trauma.

FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION

Negligence

54. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

55. Defendants owed a duty of care to Plaintiff.

56. To the extent defendants claim that the injuries to Plaintiff by the defendant police officers were unintentionally caused and that the force used by the defendants against her was unintentional, then the defendants breached that duty of care by, among other things, tightly handcuffing her and causing physical injury.

57. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York.

58. All of the foregoing occurred without any fault or provocation by Plaintiff.

59. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

60. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

61. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, emotional, and psychological injuries.

SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION

Unlawful Stop, Question, and Search

62. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

63. The illegal approach, pursuit, stop, and grab employed by defendants herein terminated Plaintiff's freedom of movement through means intentionally applied.

64. The conduct of defendants in approaching, stopping, and grabbing Plaintiff was performed under color of law and without any reasonable suspicion of criminality or other constitutionally required grounds.

65. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York.

66. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

67. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Fourth and Fourteenth Amendment Rights: Unlawful Seizure and Deprivation of Liberty

68. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

69. The individually named police officer defendants, while acting in concert and within the scope of their authority, caused Plaintiff to be seized, unlawfully searched, falsely arrested, and falsely imprisoned without reasonable suspicion and/or probable cause, in violation of Plaintiff's right to be free of an unreasonable seizure under the Fourth Amendment of the Constitution of the United States and to be free of a deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

70. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, emotional, and psychological injuries.

FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION

False Arrest/Imprisonment

71. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

72. The acts and conduct of the defendants constitute false arrest and false imprisonment under the laws of the State of New York and the United States Constitution. Defendants intended to confine Plaintiff and, in fact, confined Plaintiff, and Plaintiff was conscious of the confinement. In addition, Plaintiff did not consent to the confinement and the confinement was not otherwise privileged.

73. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York and the United States Constitution.

74. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

75. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

76. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to loss of liberty, emotional and psychological injuries.

FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Plaintiff's Fourth and Fourteenth Amendment Rights: Excessive Force

77. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

78. The use of excessive force by defendants by, amongst other things, tightly handcuffing her and placing their hands inside her religious head covering, constituted objectively unreasonable physical seizures of Plaintiff in violation of her rights under the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States and to be free of a deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

79. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Negligent Infliction of Emotional Distress

80. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

81. By the actions described herein, defendants, each acting individually and in concert with each other, engaged in extreme and outrageous conduct, conduct utterly intolerable in a civilized community, which negligently caused severe emotional distress to Plaintiff.

82. Despite their express knowledge that Plaintiff was a practicing Muslim and the restrictions associated therewith, the defendant officers forced, but compulsion and intimidation, Plaintiff to remove her head covering, exposing her hair to numerous men.

83. The acts and conduct of the defendants were the direct and proximate cause of injury and damage to Plaintiff and violated Plaintiff's statutory and common law rights as guaranteed Plaintiff by the laws and Constitution of the State of New York.

84. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York.

85. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

86. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

87. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Negligent Hiring, Retention, Training, and Supervision

88. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

89. The City of New York and its employees, servants, and/or agents acting within the scope of their employment did negligently hire, retain, train, and supervise defendants, individuals who were unfit for the performance of police duties on the aforementioned dates at the aforementioned locations.

90. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

EIGHTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Failure to Intervene

91. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

92. The defendants that did not physically touch Plaintiff but were present when other officers violated Plaintiff's Constitutional Rights had an affirmative duty to intervene on behalf of Plaintiff, whose constitutional rights were being violated in their presence by other officers.

93. Defendants failed to intervene to prevent the unlawful conduct described herein.

94. As a result of the foregoing, Plaintiff suffered serious, debilitating, and permanent emotional and psychological injury, her liberty was restricted for an extended period of time, she was put in fear for her safety, and she was humiliated and subject to other physical constraints.

95. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York.

96. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

97. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

98. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, emotional, and psychological injuries.

NINTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Fourth and Fourteenth Amendment Rights: Denial of Right to Fair Trial/Due Process

99. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

100. Defendants, individually and collectively, manufactured and/or withheld false evidence and forwarded this false evidence to prosecutors in the Kings County District Attorney's Office.

101. Defendants filled out false and misleading police reports and forwarded them to prosecutors in the Kings County District Attorney's Office.

102. Defendants signed false and misleading criminal court affidavits and forwarded them to prosecutors in the Kings County District Attorney's Office.

103. In withholding/creating false evidence against Plaintiff, and in providing/withholding information with respect thereto, defendants violated Plaintiff's

constitutional right to due process and a fair trial under the New York State Constitution and under the Due Process Clause of the Fifth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States and to be free to deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

104. As a result of the foregoing, Plaintiff sustained, inter alia, loss of the right to due process and a fair trial, loss of liberty, emotional distress, embarrassment and humiliation, and deprivation of her constitutional rights.

105. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

106. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

107. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries including, but not limited to: economic, emotional, physical, and psychological injuries.

TENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Malicious Prosecution

108. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

109. The acts and conduct of the defendants constitute malicious prosecution under the laws of the State of New York and the United States Constitution.

110. Defendants commenced and continued criminal proceedings against Plaintiff.

111. There was actual malice and an absence of probable cause for the criminal proceeding against Plaintiff and for each of the charges for which she was prosecuted.

112. The prosecution and criminal proceedings terminated in Plaintiff's favor on the aforementioned dates.

ELEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Assault

113. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

114. Defendants, their agents, servants, and employees, acting within the scope

of their employment, intentionally, willfully, and maliciously assaulted Plaintiff in that they had the real or apparent ability to cause imminent harmful and/or offensive bodily contact and intentionally did a violent and/or menacing act which threatened such contact to the Plaintiff, that such acts caused apprehension of such contact in the Plaintiff.

115. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

116. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

117. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

118. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

TWELFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Battery

119. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

120. Defendants, their agents, servants and employees, acting within the scope of their employment, intentionally, willfully and maliciously battered Plaintiff, when they, in a hostile and/or offensive manner, roughly inserted their hands into Plaintiff's religious head covering without her consent and with the intention of causing harmful and/offensive bodily contact to the Plaintiff and caused such battery.

121. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

122. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

123. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

124. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

THIRTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION**Individual Defendant Officer's Violation of Plaintiff's AC 8-802 Rights**

125. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

126. The acts of defendant officers constituted conduct under color of any law, ordinance, rule, regulation, custom, or usage.

127. The acts of defendant officers caused Plaintiff to be deprived of her rights under 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 802, to wit: to be secure in her person, house, papers, and effects against unreasonable searches and seizures, and to be secure against the use of excessive force regardless of whether such force is used in connection with a search or seizure.

128. The defendant officers, while in uniform, unlawfully seized, frisked, and searched the Plaintiff, before detaining plaintiff and further causing her detention for approximately 24 hours in total.

129. By reason of the acts and omissions by defendants described above, Plaintiff has endured psychological and emotional injuries and was otherwise damaged and injured.

FOURTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION**Individual Defendant Officer's Failure to Intervene in Violation of Plaintiff's AC 8-802 Rights**

130. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

131. The acts of the defendant officers constituted conduct under color of any law, ordinance, rule, regulation, custom, or usage.

132. Defendant officers had a duty to protect Plaintiff from violations of her rights under 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 802, to wit: to be secure in her person, house, papers, and effects against unreasonable searches and seizures, and to be secure against the use of excessive force regardless of whether such force is used in connection with a search or seizure.

133. The defendants that did not physically touch Plaintiff, but were present when other officers violated Plaintiff's AC 8-802 rights against unreasonable search and seizure and excessive force had an affirmative duty to intervene on behalf of Plaintiff, whose constitutional rights were being violated in their presence by other officers.

134. Defendants failed to intervene to prevent the unlawful conduct described herein, and thereby failed in their duty to intervene to protect Plaintiff from violation of her rights.

135. By reason of the acts and omissions by defendants described above, Plaintiff has endured psychological and emotional injuries and was otherwise damaged and injured.

FIFTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

City-Employer's Liability for Defendant Officer's Violation of Plaintiff's AC 8-802 Rights

136. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

137. Defendant officers are "covered individuals," as defined in 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 - 801 in that they are employees of the Police Department or persons appointed by the Police Commissioner as a Special Patrolman.

138. The City of New York, as the employer of the covered individual defendant officers, is liable to the Plaintiff for the wrongdoing of the covered individual defendant officers.

139. The acts of defendant officers constituted conduct under color of any law, ordinance, rule, regulation, custom, or usage.

140. The acts of defendant officers caused Plaintiff to be deprived of her rights under 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 802, to wit: to be secure in her person, house, papers, and effects against unreasonable searches and seizures, and to be secure against the use of excessive force regardless of whether such force is used in connection with a search or seizure.

141. The defendant officers, while in uniform, unlawfully seized, frisked, and searched the Plaintiff, before detaining plaintiff and further causing her detention for approximately 24 hours in total.

142. By reason of the acts and omissions by defendants described above, Plaintiff has endured psychological and emotional injuries and was otherwise damaged and injured.

SIXTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

City-Employer's Liability for Defendant Officer's Failure to Intervene in Violation of Plaintiff's AC 8-802 Rights

143. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

144. Defendant officers are “covered individuals,” as defined in 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 - 801 in that they are employees of the Police Department or persons appointed by the Police Commissioner as a Special Patrolman.

145. The City of New York, as the employer of the covered individual defendant officers, is liable to the Plaintiff for the wrongdoing of the covered individual defendant officers.

146. The acts of defendant officers constituted conduct under color of any law, ordinance, rule, regulation, custom, or usage.

147. Defendant officers had a duty to protect Plaintiff from violations of her rights under 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 802, to wit: to be secure in her person, house, papers, and effects against unreasonable searches and seizures, and to be secure against the use of excessive force regardless of whether such force is used in connection with a search or seizure.

148. The defendants that did not physically touch Plaintiff but were present when other officers violated Plaintiff’s AC 8 – 802 rights against unreasonable search and seizure and excessive force had an affirmative duty to intervene on behalf of Plaintiff, whose constitutional rights were being violated in their presence by other officers.

149. Defendants failed to intervene to prevent the unlawful conduct described herein, and thereby failed in their duty to intervene to protect Plaintiff from violation of her rights.

150. By reason of the acts and omissions by defendants described above, Plaintiff has endured physical, psychological, and emotional injuries and was otherwise damaged and injured.

SEVENTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of the First Amendment of the United States Constitution

151. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

152. Federal legislation has been enacted to demonstrate our robust national commitment to the free exercise of religion and to prohibit the government from placing a substantial burden on religious practice and beliefs. This legislation, which reflects an increased awareness of and support for religious interests in practices like covering, “shall be construed in favor of a broad protection of religious exercise, to the maximum extent permitted by . . . the Constitution.” 42 U.S.C. § 2000cc-3(g). The statute even “may require a government to incur expenses in its own operations to avoid imposing a substantial burden on religious exercise.” *Id.*

153. 42 U.S.C. § 1983 prohibits any person acting under color of state law, custom, or usage to deprive a citizen of rights secured by the Constitution.

154. At all relevant times, the defendants acted under color of state law.

155. Under the First Amendment of the Constitution of the United States of America, Plaintiff has the right to freely exercise her religion.

156. By forcing Plaintiff to remove her hijab and by touching her bare hair for photographs, defendants deprived Plaintiff of her right to freely exercise her religion in contravention of the Free Exercise Clause.

157. The United States Constitution does not require that a Muslim remove her head covering when sitting for an arrest photo. *See Jamilla Clark, et al. v. City of New York*, 18 Civ. 2334 (AT) (KHP) (SDNY, 2021).

158. As a direct and proximate result of the defendants' unlawful, discriminatory conduct, Plaintiff has sustained damages, and has suffered mental anguish, physical and emotional distress, humiliation, and embarrassment.

EIGHTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Article I, § 3 of the New York State Constitution

159. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

160. Article I, Section 3 of the Constitution of the State of New York provides that "the free exercise and enjoyment of religious profession and worship, without discrimination or preference, shall forever be allowed in this state to all humankind." McKinney's Const. Art. 1, § 3.

161. Defendant's insistence that Plaintiff, and indeed other arrestees who wear religious head coverings remove them to be photographed violates Article I, Section 3 by disallowing the free exercise of religion.

162. As a direct and proximate result of the defendants' unlawful, discriminatory conduct, Plaintiff has sustained damages, and has suffered mental anguish, physical and emotional distress, humiliation, and embarrassment.

NINETEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Article I, § 12 of the New York State Constitution

163. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

164. Such conduct breached the protections guaranteed to plaintiff by the New York State Constitution, including but not limited to, Article 1, §§ 1, 6, 8, 9, 11, and 12, and including the following rights:

- i. freedom from unreasonable search and seizure of her person and property;
- ii. freedom from arrest without probable cause;
- iii. freedom from false imprisonment, that being wrongfully detained without good faith, reasonable suspicion, or legal justification, and of which wrongful detention plaintiff was aware and did not consent;
- iv. freedom from the lodging of false charges against her by police officers and prosecutors, including on information and belief, by some or all of the individual defendants; and
- v. freedom from deprivation of liberty without due process of law.

165. As a direct and proximate result of defendants' deprivations of Plaintiff's rights, privileges, and immunities guaranteed by the New York State Constitution, Plaintiff suffered physical, psychological, economic, and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of liberty.

166. As a result of the above tortious conduct, Plaintiff was caused to suffer physical, psychological, economic, and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of liberty.

167. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, the City of New York is liable for the conduct of the Individual Defendants and any damages they caused under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

JURY DEMAND

168. Plaintiff hereby demands trial by jury of all issues properly triable thereby.

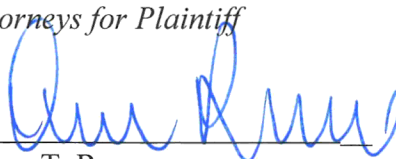
PRAYER FOR RELIEF

WHEREFORE, Plaintiff, TIFFANY TEAGUE, demands judgment against the defendants on each cause of action in amounts to be determined upon the trial of this action which exceeds the jurisdiction of lower courts, inclusive of punitive damages and attorneys' fees inclusive of costs and disbursements of this action, interest and such other relief as is appropriate under the law, and that the Plaintiff recover the cost of the suit herein, including reasonable attorney's fees pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988 and 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 801 *et seq.*.

Dated: New York, New York
March 6, 2023

SHULMAN & HILL, PLLC
Attorneys for Plaintiff

By:


Omar T. Russo
1 State Street Plaza, 15th Floor
New York, New York 10004
(212) 203-1090

TO: THE CITY OF NEW YORK, Corporation Counsel, 100 Church Street, New York, New York 10007

NYPD DETECTIVE SONEY VARGHESE, Shield No. 3642, 73rd Precinct; 1470 East New York Avenue; Brooklyn, New York 11212

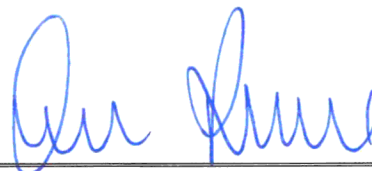
NYPD DETECTIVE ROBERT DECK, Shield No. 2493, 81st Precinct; 30 Ralph Avenue, Brooklyn, New York 11221

ATTORNEY'S VERIFICATION

OMAR RUSSO, an attorney duly admitted to practice before the Courts of the State of New York, affirms the following to be true under the penalties of perjury:

I am an associate of the law firm of **SHULMAN-HILL PLLC**, I have read the annexed **VERIFIED COMPLAINT** and know the contents thereof, and the same are true to my knowledge, except those matters therein which are stated to be alleged upon information and belief, and as to those matters I believe them to be true. My belief, as to those matters therein not stated upon knowledge, is based upon facts, records, and other pertinent information contained in my files. The reason this verification is made by me and not Plaintiff is because Plaintiff does not reside in the county wherein I maintain my office.

DATED: New York, New York
March 6, 2024



OMAR T. RUSSO

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

TIFFANY TEAGUE,

Plaintiff,

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, NYPD DETECTIVE SONEY VARGHESE, Shield No. 3642,
NYPD DETECTIVE ROBERT DECK, Shield No. 2493, and NYPD POLICE OFFICERS JOHN
AND JANE DOES NUMBERS ONE THROUGH SIX,

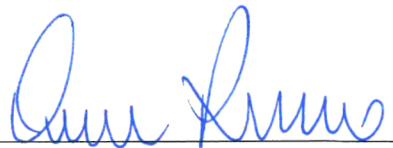
Defendants.

SUMMONS AND VERIFIED COMPLAINT

SHULMAN & HILL, PLLC
Attorneys for the Plaintiff
One State Street Plaza, 15th Floor
New York, New York 10004
Tel: 212-221-1000
www.shulman-hill.com

Pursuant to 22 NYCRR 130-1.1, the undersigned, an attorney admitted to practice in the courts of New York State, certifies that, upon information and belief and reasonable inquiry, the contentions contained in the annexed document are not frivolous.

Dated: March 6, 2024


OMAR T. RUSSO

